

The Role of Emotional Intelligence in Daily Spiritual Experience

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Abstract

This study examined whether emotional intelligence, as measured by the Trait Meta-Mood Scale (TMMS; Salovey et al., 1995), predicted daily spiritual experience among individuals at a private Midwestern university. Specifically, the three TMMS subscales: Attention to Feelings, Clarity of Feelings, and Mood Repair. They were examined as predictors of daily spiritual experience as measured by the Daily Spiritual Experience Scale (DSES; Underwood, 2006). Fifty-one participants were recruited from the University of St. Thomas via QR code posters displayed across campus. A standard multiple regression revealed that the overall model was statistically significant, $F(3, 47) = 6.20$, $p = .001$, $R^2 = .28$, indicating that the three subscales collectively explained 28% of the variance in daily spiritual experience. Attention to Feelings emerged as the strongest individual predictor ($\beta = .363$, $p = .006$), followed by Clarity of Feelings ($\beta = .271$, $p = .036$) and Mood Repair ($\beta = .256$, $p = .047$). These findings suggest that emotional intelligence, particularly the awareness of one's emotional states, may serve as a psychological foundation through which individuals access and engage in spiritual experience. Limitations and future directions are discussed.

The Role of Emotional Intelligence in Daily Spiritual Experience

The capacity to connect with something greater than oneself is a central dimension of human experience, yet the psychological factors that facilitate this connection have yet to be completely understood. Spiritual experience can be defined as the subjective sense of connection to the transcendent, the sacred, or something beyond the self. It has been linked to a range of positive psychological and health outcomes, including greater well-being, resilience, and meaning-making (Underwood, 2006). Understanding what predicts daily spiritual experience may therefore have meaningful implications for both psychological science and applied practice.

One promising but underexplored predictor of spiritual experience, is emotional intelligence (EI). Broadly defined as the ability to perceive, understand, regulate, and use emotions effectively, EI has been associated with a range of positive psychological outcomes, including mental, social, and physical health in university students (Extremera & Fernández-Berrocal, 2006). More recent work has suggested that emotional abilities may develop before spiritual ones, positioning EI as a potential psychological foundation for spiritual engagement (Sodhi, 2016). Further, EI and spirituality together have been found to predict psychological well-being, suggesting a meaningful relationship between the two constructs (Siddique & Mosanya, 2025).

The Trait Meta-Mood Scale (TMMS; Salovey et al., 1995) operationalizes EI through three distinct subscales: Attention to Feelings, Clarity of Feelings, and Mood Repair. Attention to Feelings refers to the degree to which individuals notice and reflect on their emotional states. Clarity of Feelings reflects the ability to clearly identify and discriminate among emotional experiences. Mood Repair captures the motivation and ability to regulate and improve one's

emotional state. These three components represent different facets of emotional processing that may each impose a unique relationship to spiritual experience.

Walter et al. (2024) found that emotional intelligence significantly predicted life satisfaction in emerging adults, suggesting that the ability to recognize and regulate emotions may be a broader reason for positive subjective experiences, including those of a spiritual nature. The current study extends this line of inquiry by directly testing whether the three TMMS subscales predict daily spiritual experience in a university sample.

So, given these theoretical and empirical foundation pieces, the present study examined whether Attention to Feelings, Clarity of Feelings, and Mood Repair would significantly predict daily spiritual experience among individuals at a private Midwestern university. It was hypothesized that all three TMMS subscales would collectively and individually predict daily spiritual experience, with Attention to Feelings expected to emerge as the strongest predictor given the centrality of emotional awareness in facilitating introspective and transcendent states.

Method

Participants

Participants were 51 individuals recruited from the University of St. Thomas, a private Catholic university located in St. Paul, Minnesota. The sample included students, faculty, and staff recruited via QR code posters displayed in high-traffic areas across campus. The sample was predominantly White (approximately 82%), with additional participants identifying as Hispanic/Latino (approximately 10%), Asian (approximately 6%), and Black/African American (approximately 2%). The religiously affiliated context of the university is relevant to the interpretation of findings, as the sample was expected to include a high proportion of individuals with existing spiritual orientations.

Measures

Trait Meta-Mood Scale (TMMS). The TMMS (Salovey et al., 1995) is a 48-item self-report measure of emotional intelligence consisting of three subscales: Attention to Feelings (e.g., “I pay a lot of attention to how I feel”), Clarity of Feelings (e.g., “I can often define my feelings”), and Mood Repair (e.g., “Although I am sometimes sad, I have a mostly optimistic outlook”). Items are rated on a 5-point Likert scale ranging from 1 (strongly disagree) to 5 (strongly agree). Subscale scores were computed by averaging item responses, with higher scores indicating greater attention to feelings, emotional clarity, and mood repair ability, respectively. The TMMS has demonstrated acceptable reliability and validity in prior research (Salovey et al., 1995).

Daily Spiritual Experience Scale (DSES). The DSES (Underwood, 2006) is a 16-item measure assessing the frequency of lived spiritual experience in everyday life (e.g., “I feel deep inner peace or harmony”). Items are rated on a 6-point scale ranging from 1 (never or almost

never) to 6 (many times a day), with higher scores reflecting more frequent daily spiritual experience. The DSES has demonstrated strong psychometric properties across diverse samples (Underwood, 2006).

Design and Procedure

This study employed a cross-sectional, correlational design. Participants completed an online survey distributed via a QR code link. The survey was about 6-7 minutes in total to complete. It included demographic items and the two measures described above. Data were collected during the spring semester of the 2025–2026 academic year. Informed consent was obtained from all participants prior to participation. The study was reviewed and approved in accordance with institutional research guidelines.

Data Analysis

A standard multiple regression was conducted to examine whether the three TMMS subscales (Attention to Feelings, Clarity of Feelings, and Mood Repair) significantly predicted daily spiritual experience. Prior to analysis, data were screened for missing values. Cases with missing data on any of the four scale scores were excluded listwise, resulting in an analytic sample of 51 complete cases. All analyses were conducted using SPSS.

Results

Means and standard deviations for all study variables are reported in Table 1. Attention to Feelings ($M = 2.89$, $SD = 0.48$), Clarity of Feelings ($M = 3.23$, $SD = 0.48$), and Mood Repair ($M = 3.28$, $SD = 0.43$) were measured on a 5-point scale, while Daily Spiritual Experience ($M = 2.66$, $SD = 0.95$) was measured on a 6-point scale.

A standard multiple regression was conducted to examine whether the three TMMS subscales predicted daily spiritual experience. The overall model was statistically significant, $F(3, 47) = 6.20$, $p = .001$, $R^2 = .28$, Adjusted $R^2 = .24$, indicating that the three subscales collectively explained 28% of the variance in daily spiritual experience.

Attention to Feelings emerged as the strongest predictor of daily spiritual experience ($\beta = .363$, $p = .006$), followed by Clarity of Feelings ($\beta = .271$, $p = .036$) and Mood Repair ($\beta = .256$, $p = .047$). All three subscales were statistically significant individual predictors at the $p < .05$ level, providing full support for the study hypothesis.

Table 1

Descriptive Statistics for Study Variables

Variable	M	SD	Scale Range
Attention to Feelings	2.89	0.48	1–5
Clarity of Feelings	3.23	0.48	1–5
Mood Repair	3.28	0.43	1–5
Daily Spiritual Experience	2.66	0.95	1–6

Note. N = 51

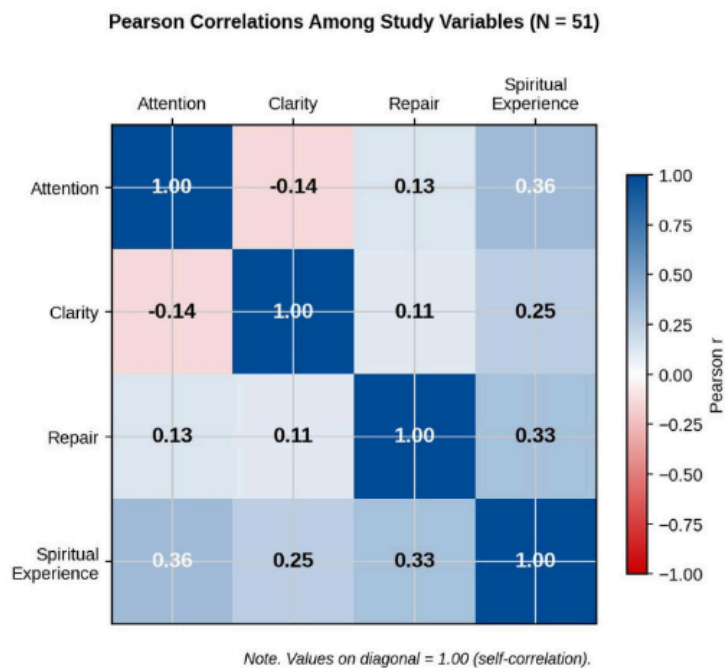
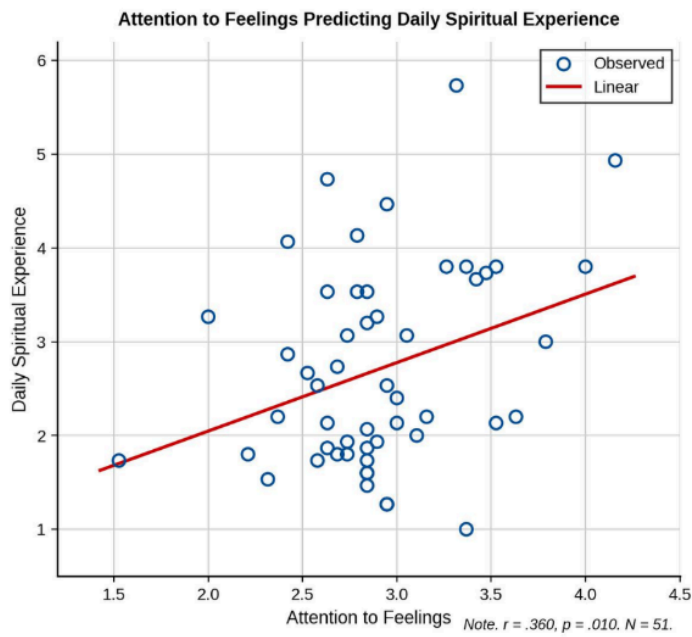
Figure 2.

Table 3

Multiple Regression Results Predicting Daily Spiritual Experience

Predictor	B	SE	β	t	p
Attention to Feelings	0.81	0.28	.363	2.88	.006
Clarity of Feelings	0.62	0.29	.271	2.16	.036
Mood Repair	0.66	0.33	.256	2.04	.047

Note. $N = 51$. $R^2 = .28$, $F(3, 47) = 6.20$, $p = .001$.**Figure 4**

Discussion

The present study examined whether the three subscales of the Trait Meta-Mood Scale: Attention to Feelings, Clarity of Feelings, and Mood Repair, would predict daily spiritual experience in a sample of 51 individuals recruited from a private Catholic university. Consistent with the study hypothesis, all three subscales significantly predicted daily spiritual experience both collectively and individually, with the overall model explaining 28% of the variance in the outcome variable. These findings extend prior work linking emotional intelligence and spirituality (Siddique & Mosanya, 2025; Sodhi, 2016) by demonstrating that facets of emotional processing are associated with the frequency of lived spiritual experience.

Attention to Feelings emerged as the strongest predictor, suggesting that simply noticing and attending to one's emotional states may be more central to daily spiritual experience than either clarity or regulation. This finding aligns with theoretical perspectives that put emotional awareness as a prerequisite for deeper self-connection and, by extension, connection to the transcendent (Sodhi, 2016). Note: derived from a correlational study, one could argue inverse-causation. Individuals who are more attuned to their inner emotional life may be better positioned to recognize and engage with the subtle, affective dimensions of spiritual experience.

Clarity of Feelings and Mood Repair also emerged as significant predictors, supporting the idea that emotional intelligence as a broader construct. These findings are consistent with Walter et al. (2024), who found EI to be a significant predictor of life satisfaction in emerging adults, and suggest that the ability to understand and regulate one's emotions may provide a broader psychological foundation for positive subjective experiences of a spiritual nature.

Overall, it is necessary to note that participants were drawn from a Catholic university context in which spiritual engagement is culturally embedded and normative. This religious and

institutional context may have undoubtedly amplified the observed relationships, as individuals already embedded in a spiritual community are likely more attuned to the emotional dimensions of that experience. Consequently, these findings may be particularly coherent and expected within this population, though they may not generalize to more religiously diverse or secular samples.

Limitations

Several limitations should be noted. First, the sample was a small convenience sample ($N = 51$) drawn from a single private Midwestern university, limiting generalizability. Second, the cross-sectional design cannot claim causal inference; it is not possible to determine whether emotional intelligence leads to greater spiritual experience or vice versa. Third, religiosity was not *formally* measured or controlled for, despite being a likely moderating variable given the institutional context. The absence of a validated religiosity measure represents a meaningful gap in the study design. Finally, the sample was predominantly White and Catholic, further restricting the generalizability of findings across diverse populations.

Future Directions

Future research should seek to replicate these findings with larger and more diverse samples across multiple institutions and religious affiliations. The researcher would love to see this done at other universities, with populations reaching beyond Christian individuals, including Islamic, Jewish, etc. Including a validated religiosity measure as a covariate would allow researchers to better isolate the role of emotional intelligence beyond just religious engagement. Longitudinal designs would be good for examining whether emotional intelligence predicts the development of spiritual experience over time. Additionally, exploring potential mediating or moderating variables (such as mindfulness, self-compassion, or attachment style) could yield a

more nuanced understanding of the mechanisms linking emotional intelligence to spiritual experience.

Conclusion

This study provides evidence that emotional intelligence, as measured by the TMMS, is significantly associated with daily spiritual experience in a university sample. Attention to Feelings emerged as the strongest predictor, showing the importance of emotional awareness in facilitating spiritual engagement. These findings contribute to the direction of spiritual research by connecting psychological and spiritual dimensions of human experience, and suggest that fostering emotional intelligence may have implications for spiritual well-being.

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